

lasting structures; they would move to the next valley . . . the next hollow . . . the next county . . . soon, anyway. And why not throw the refrigerator out the door? It was such a big wilderness . . . so rich in everything, especially land. Throw out the trash and move on. The attitude was well adapted to the place. Why go to all the trouble of building proper garages—and proper houses—if you’re going to move on soon, anyway?

But it is not an attitude that encourages long-lasting wealth. We must be more like the Swiss and the Dutch than the West Virginians or the Haitians. We have to make sacrifices now, for the benefit of the future.

Unfortunately, it may be a future in which we personally cannot participate. For it is a distant future we are talking about, 20 . . . 50 years ahead.

It is only by looking ahead, into a future we may not be able to see with our own eyes, that we can build enduring wealth. And by the way, there’s more to “wealth” than just money.

One thing you can see for yourself: Rome wasn’t built in a day. Nor were the Jardins du Luxembourg. The architectural wealth of Europe is the result of centuries of investment and preservation. The hovels and shacks disappear. The Louvre and Versailles are still there. They are part of Europe’s public wealth.

There is immense private wealth, too. You can have an ugly house. Or a pretty one. The values, from a tax—or even a market—standpoint could be the same. The pretty one takes more effort to get right. Even over generations.

We bought the Chateau d’Ouzilly for a pittance in 1994. The owners sold it to us because they could no longer afford to keep it up. We discovered that we could barely afford it, either. The correct translation of the word *chateau* is “money pit.” Most people would argue that it is a wealth destroyer, not a wealth builder. Most people would say that it is a way to deprive future generations of wealth, not to save it for them.

But life is funny . . . curious . . . and full of ironies. The previous owners had bought the chateau for nothing, paying for it in revolutionary scrip during the French Revolution. The local nobility had fled France for their lives. The chateau was there for the taking.